SYNCRETISM: ORGANIC FLOW OF ARTICULATED MORPHOLOGIES

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ABSTRACT

This paper presents some ideas on my compositional approach to a series of pieces I called "syncretisms". I will offer a view of the main operations involved and the conceptual particulars derived from the resulting sonority.

1. INTRODUCTION

To define "syncretism" I will use the definition used by composer Horacio Vaggione for the liner notes of my 1994 CD "Illegal Edge":

Syncretism: to merge everything together with the morphology of a (articulated) continuity. [i]

This paper focuses on electroacoustic compositions that include folk music or folk-indigenous music referential material particularly from NorthWest Argentina. However, the concept of fusion, hybridization and syncretism should not be restricted to referential materials in a particular medium. Hybridization is a cultural phenomenon present in many countries and without a doubt it generates discussions on the transformation of the inner texture of society and its inevitable effect on the art world of the 21st Century.

2. RELIGIOUS BACKGROUND

My first encounter with the word "syncretism" was in 1993 when a "santero" priest showed me a crucifix with Christ on one side and an image of Obatalá (Santeria deity) embedded on its back. He explained to me that the cross was the only way to survive the Church's imposition of faith in 16th Century Latin America. The cross was a syncretic object. It served both faiths and it bore an ambiguous yet pragmatic identity that satisfied the Church and the Santeros as well. The tension created by the ambiguity did not need to be solved (could not) and the symmetry of one priest on each side looking at what each one considered the "real" faith, gives the impression that the syncretic object, however complicated it may seem, is not complicated at all in that context. Actually, it makes a lot of sense. The constant flow of information (identities) around the cross, a loop of meanings, the pragmatic use of a symbol, an integration of alleged contradictions and the un-resolved tension between multiple discourses, made me realize that I was thinking in very similar terms when composing my pieces.

3. SYNCRETIC OBJECTS

The syncretic object is therefore a sonic entity that projects the view of the observer from his or her point of listening. When two or more elements are inseparable but identifiable parts of a context, their respective constitutive natures are re-signified when they enter in contact with the other elements of the group that they have come to relate to (in composition, by the decision of the composer). It is the composer who creates the context of belongingness and chooses which elements will interact and how they will behave. The composer must design methods of interaction between the elements that will be

understood by the listener as articulative markers, formal meaningful creators of sonic sense.
Any computer process such as filtering, phase vocoding, convolution, granulation affect a sound at different levels changing its nature, producing an output which represents its originality, its capacity to represent itself in its original existence, or its loss of its originality becoming convolved to an unrecognizable state, in which case it simply becomes something else.

A syncretic process involves therefore the recognition of a sound as an entity but also as a bearer of multiple identities some which may change while others remain the same. The result will be a structure whose balance principles are based on the composer's control of the nature of each element. What I call the "nature" of a sound may become its "organic quality" which the composer must define before entering in the structural game of construction.

The composer then chooses the level of intervention in the organic quality or nature of the sound which is the same as to say that the composer controls the level or referentiality that a sound will have in the composition. And that focus on control is what will determine that a composition is unique in its own syncretic existence.

When two sounds are actively operating in a context, energy is generated at many levels from their innate operative behaviour producing tension in the context. This tension is constant and doesn't resolve (as it does in a traditional tonal context) but is replaced by other dualities. This tensional dualism is created by the heterogeneous quality of the sources, which move in time and space with undeterred resolve. A syncretic composition therefore doesn't attempt to solve dualisms but to highlight them projecting the articulation as well as the sources. There is a sense of ambiguity in almost all the extension of these pieces which leaves the listener with a sense of continuous dis-continuity, a formal imbalance saved by the articulation proposed on each particular moment.

4. HYBRIDATION

This "hybrid" sensation is well described and explained by Argentine anthropologist Nestor Garcia Canclini who describes the "cultural hybridisation process" that Latin American countries go through today and how this may be a way out of the powerful mandates of modernist thought.

He uses the word "hybrid" to describe a culture that no longer can be considered as pure (following strict rules of Modernism) and that is defined by the level of fusion present at any given time and context.

"When one tries to understand transferences between borders and frontiers of countries, in the fluid networks that communicate peoples, ethnic groups and classes, what's popular, cultured, national and foreign appear not as entities but as stages. A stage….where a particular narrative is staged. It is important to include in that re-conversion, the re-staging, processes of hybridation through which the representations of society are elaborated with a dramatic sense.

To further clarify these distinctions, and to add yet another difficulty to the compositional process, I will cite a reference from this same book from Brazilian musicologist Jose Jorge de Carvalho: (referring to television, video-games, video clips, etc):

"*…they promise happiness coming from the cultural industry…they are basically the experience of the transitory: they help people, who live a fast and changing life, to get rid of the weight and responsibility of memory.*

Whereas in the popular and cultured arts they work within a tradition, where self-referentiality and constant commentary are essential in the establishment of a hermeneutic that's basic to their existence, contributing to the building of a collective memory."

In a syncretic composition, the clash of heterogeneities is confronted with yet another type of sound event: sounds with no history or attachment to traditions. Sounds that create a transient void that allows the piece to become temporarily "from nowhere". This void is essencial to provide a sense unlimited possibility. It embodies an abstract sonic self that neutralizes the imposed intentions of cultural attachments.

5. ARTICULATION

When confronted, two or more sound objects

share a musical space but connections are not yet implemented. The composer chooses paths of relations and these are called "articulations". The distance between sounds in any context is then bridged by these articulatory decisions which will give the piece its meaning, coherence and expressiveness. Articulations therefore are trajectories between sound objects that connect or transform them at multiple levels. Many articulations can be applied to a single sound event connecting it with one or more sound objects or with an electronic transformation process which will create yet another type of articulation with its new and old selves. In fig. 1, the chart shows a typical flow of a nodal syncretic context. A node may represent operations, meanings, sound typology, causality, sound parameters. Each connection represents a distinct articulation. One node may be articulated with many other nodes in different ways. Fig. 2 shows two sound parameters from different sound objects related by two articulations: high speed speech and expansion with phase vocoder x 2. The range of articulative choices is unlimited. From convolution and phase vocoding to rhythmic counterpoint, sound objects are subject to all sort of manipulations that will change or reinforce its identity by comparison to other sounds in the context. Sounds are "victims" of an "assault" (see later under "Patrimony") on its integrity, and its "nature" is challenged by the composer's action on it. An articulation becomes a game of dualities and the new "syncretic" context is the arena where the challenge takes place.

6. AMBIGUITY

In my first pieces which dealt with issues of a materiality centered on concrete folk sources, the issue of abstraction became immediately fundamental. The discussion of the Presence-Absence dynamic of the materials was for me challenging due to my own aesthetic belief regarding referentiality. My decisions, then, were that I would establish a mechanism which would control the dynamic of the Presence-Absence dualism of the folk material, and would relate it with the other synthesized, modified, instrumental sounds to build this "syncretic context" of relations in many different temporal and structural levels. When we deal with dualisms the issue of ambiguity is key. In composing syncretic pieces, this notion became more and more important especially due to the type of criticism I was receiving: Lack of directionality, gratuitous use of referential materials, inappropriate handling of sacred texts, indifference towards meaningful ancestral cultural heritage and on more positive reviews, a sense of conviviality of the heterogeneous, dissimilar sources which in a surprising manner were actually creating meaningful syntax, organically.

Ambiguity then was a force of organization since some sound events had a strong sense of directionality but others had not. Therefore, the temporality of the whole was affected profoundly since no single sense of real direction was present but instead there were many different senses of direction, including a non-directional, static sense of flow. Then a syncretic composition deals with the issue of ambiguity in the positive sense of the word and not the negative one. Instead of "it is neither this nor that" we go to "it is a bit of this and a bit of that".

7. ORGANIC FLOW

In a hybrid context, the sense of organic flow becomes fundamental to understand when materials stop delivering a "communal" meaningful discourse to replace it with an iconic representation of itself or, in words of Brian Ferneyhough " a tendentially absolutist iconic pretension…" or "strangely visible black holes, at the still center of their own burnt-out identity".[ii]

Form is an illusion of continuity created by many participants. It is an illusion because there is no such thing as a continuous indivisible texture that is heard as just one thing by everyone. There is always a detail in a micro, meso or macro level that will be detected and thus will cause an articulated break up in the whole. Time is continuous as long as there are single parts with their own temporality. This type of reception creates a sense of continuity of articulated actions. Organic flow does occur within the boundaries of articulation. Continuity is a creation both on the part of the composer and the listener.

8. INTEGRATION

I propose through this idea to contemplate the integration as a form of understanding each member of a group individually but at the same

time in its contribution to its group, however transient the group might be. An identity (that may last a few seconds or milliseconds) is projected just by being in contact with other sound impulses, spectra, voices, or any meaningful sound in the context. In a network-oriented syncretic structure, any sound can become functional and determinant of form and thus any meaning may be used to change the macro structure and the overall perception of the piece.

9. PATRIMONY

When materials belong to cultural contexts (most of them do), the use and transformation of these materials can be taken as an "appropriation" or "assault" to the patrimonial property. We may include here texts, repertoire of songs or chants, religious repertoire, speech recordings, traditional instruments, narrations of sacred texts etc. We should understand the sound in the context of the culture and its tradition and what it means to those who protect it, cultivate it or even adore it.

It may be useful to explain this word and concept to better understand the implications of dealing with musical sources that are created outside the borders of our own. Patrimony or cultural heritage is used here as a post-modernist construct. According to it, patrimony evolves: we must recognize the past so that present and future generations may re-interpret it. The subject looks at patrimony that evolves from the point of view of his/her historical context, this way the new perspectives enrich it. The post-modern notion then accepts a patrimony that evolves through interpretation and therefore from significance and symbolism, because when it is re-signified, it is also re-symbolized, that is, it acquires a different or new symbolic character. The post-modern view is the historical perspective of the subject that observes, filtered by his/her psychological and affective impression of the phenomenon.

10. SYNCRETISM: ASSAULTING IDENTITY

We begin with a profound understanding of the identity or multiple identities of a sound. Sound events have operative features that may be common to other sounds and thus we tend to group them analyzing and interpreting based on those features. Then, we work at the perceptual level and the sound becomes part of a complex process of creation and reception whereby the composer creates the symbolic sonic form.

The constant reflexion and reaction to the sound, transforming it, re-connecting it to other sounds can be called a creative "assault" to the identity of a source. This may mean to contradict the original purpose of it in its belonging to a different cultural musical or sonic context. We negotiate in a "neutral" ground, where artistic freedom is key, and changes occur. The consequences are these new syncretic contexts where new tensions and significances are attributed to the sounds and the old patrimonial ownership, has given way to a new "sonic habitat" for sounds to behave and operate differently. A case for lost identity and purpose may be raised but the new composition is justified on its own aesthetic purpose. Every sound is now a participant and actively creates articulative contexts where complexity, multiplicity, diversity and a sense of dynamic individuality complete an imbalanced and ambiguous yet highly articulated composition.

11. EXAMPLES

"INDIA VIEJA, sincretismo #1" Acousmatic (1991)*

I will now give an example of an electroacoustic syncretic piece and the reaction to it from a highly recognized Argentinean ethno-musicologist specialized in folk musics from the NorthWest of Argentina, Leda Valladares. In her very honest and generous letter from 1995, she comments on my first syncretic piece: "Old Indian Woman". She writes:

"I liked your work and the fact that my compilations on bagualas and vidalas served you as inspiration to deal with something cosmic and secret. I would prefer that the sonic textures were less dense and more incisive with respect to the voice, which in such nakedness and mystery has a lot to discover and study. The contrasts of sonorities distract from the magnetism and geneticism of the ancestral chanting, an endless reserve. To study it and to show its depths will be richer without mixing it with electronics, which sometimes invades you with pre-natal fear and paralyzes you. The ancestral chanting of the Third World is the largest reserve of music.

There you can find the mysteries to decipher, to de-frost…"

Leda Valladares is protecting the transcendental quality of the music I used, defending it to the point of denying its existence in contexts that may hurt the image she has of it, or the psychological energy she has vested in it. She believes in a pure and distinguishable status of existence of that music and anything that may undervalue it, will be deemed as impure and disposable disturbances.

"India Vieja, sincretismo #1" (Old Indian Woman) was composed at the Computer Music Center at Brooklyn College under the direction of Charles Dodge. In this piece I worked with a "baguala", a folk song, from the Coya Indian oral tradition from NorthWest Argentina. I processed the material generating textures descriptive of the song's images. One of them, the woman's desire to become young again by drinking condor's blood, was achieved slowing down her singing and drumming to depict old age and the condor's flight. This computer image intervenes in the sense of the poem and the force of the original singing style, creating new sound images absent in the original song but present now in the computer composition. The original "magic and mystery" that Valladares attributes to the style is replaced by a new hybrid sense due to my own intervention on the object which is no longer the same object but a new, syncretized one.

"UITOTOS, Sincretismo #2" (1992) 10 minutes. Acousmatic and string quartet*

In this composition my materials were bell-like synthesized sounds using pure sine tones filtered with comb / reson filters in the C-Sound software environment (using some of Jean Claude Risset's designs for bells), a recording of a cello sustained note and a recording of two native Uitoto priests reciting their version of the genesis in a magic/secret language in a hocket-type of counterpoint. One priest recited and the other replied but using the last word uttered by the first. The building of the piece centered in that rhythmic and textural qualities and the circularity of the overall sensation of the speech. The construction was about those qualities: circularity in the recurrence of events, small gestures against big ones, presence and absence of the voices, and slow speed gradually increasing at a similar pace with the eventual presence of the voices. Different trajectories (directional and non-directional), different speeds, rhythms, sonic qualities in an atmosphere of dissolution created by the reson filter quality, that would "give away" the voices very slowly. No interpretation or reference to the meaning of the text took place in this piece other than trying to assimilate the priests' ritualistic formulation. The parameters highlighted were others and the syncretic context was ruled by a different set of interpretative tools. The tape piece had a new life later as a tape and string quartet and later as a tape and violin piece.

"THE BREAKING OF THE SCREAM" (1999) 10'50". Acousmatic*

A folk song, from the oral tradition of the music of NorthWest Argentina, the "baguala" (Coya Indian song), talks about the desire of a man to compare himself with a tiger, making reference to the sexual power of the animal. The poem, by Argentine contemporary poet Pablo Anadón, is about a loved one leaving our life, and the existential sense of loneliness and abandonment that inundates our soul after the loss. The scream is a reference to both the sexuality of the folk song and the pain of abandonment of the poem, but it also connects to un-conscious and unknown fears and meanings.

In this "syncretic" environment, the elements reflect and exchange musical, acoustical and spectral qualities between one another, constantly adding new meanings to the multiple fusions that are formed in the different levels of the structure (music, poetry, rhythm, meanings, emotions, speech etc) . The words of the poem become screams, the main scream is granulated to create rhythmic textures, while the electronic sounds, derived from the voices and the reading of the poem, help create the environments where the elements will relate in multiple ways as sounds, as carriers of meaning, as creators of morphologies. In "The Breaking of the Scream" (which begins with a climactic and extreme human scream) there is an intentional exploration of the idea of excess whereby I constantly expand the dynamic range to give space to new peaks and climaxes.

CONCLUSION

In electroacoustic music, we may consider that

sounds carry a hybrid materiality that is abstracted and fused in our creative imagination to convey meaning many times in heterogeneous contexts of multiple sound events. Then we look into the sonic qualities of each sound we want to bring to our composing table, as a sort of musical anthropologist. We consider all the aspects of the sound, including the historical and traditional dimensions, as compositional.

Transformational operations (articulations) change the structures, and entities (traces) become fleeting (discreet) identities. Music becomes then a flexible structure that changes in time. We open its form to eventuality and ambiguity so that modulations can freely take place in the continuum between (as expressed by Vaggione) "autoreferential time embedded in referential sounds." A syncretic composer is liminal by nature, moving freely between borders, erasing and re-tracing them for purely aesthetic reasons.

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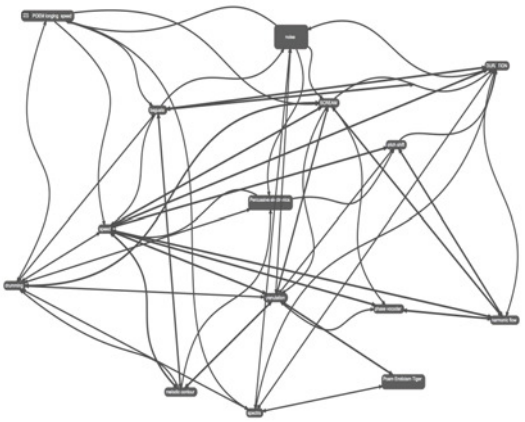


Fig. 1. *The Breaking of the Scream*. Nodal map of articulations between nodes: sounds, parameters, references, operations and meanings.

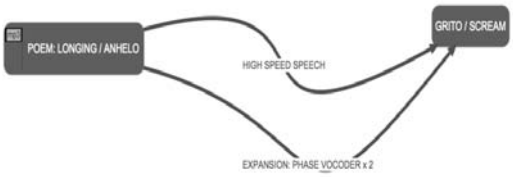


Fig. 2. *The Breaking of the Scream*. Dual articulation between two nodes: longing in the poem and the recorded scream. Two articulations are present: high speed speech contrasting with a time expansion process on the screaming voice. Emphasis on composer's own voice screaming and reciting at different speeds to provoke a dual sensation of longing and rage.

*** Pieces can be found at this link:**

https://www.myspace.com/halacjose

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NOTES

[i] HALAC, José, *Illegal Edge*, Centaur Records, Liner notes, USA, 1994

[ii] FERNEYHOUGH, Brian, *Collected writings*, Chapter: "Form – Figure – Style: An intermediate assessment (1982)", Routledge, London, 1996, page 24.